

1783 Catherine annexes the Khanate of the Crimea and orders the construction of a huge naval base at Sevastopol on the Black Sea.

1784 Russian traders from Siberia cross the Bering Strait into America and establish the first settlement in Alaska near Kodiak.

1796 On the death of Catherine the Great, her son Paul I becomes czar. He is assassinated in 1801, after a conspiracy is hatched among sections of the increasingly alienated nobility. He is succeeded by his son Alexander I.

1801 The Orthodox Christian kingdom of Georgia voluntarily unites with Russia.

1809 Russia gains Finland from Sweden.

1812 Napoleon invades Russia and within three months has entered Moscow, but the same night a terrible fire razes the city. Czar Alexander I refuses to surrender; the French, cut off from their supply lines, are forced to retreat through the Russian winter, pursued by the Russian army.

1814 Alexander I leads Russian, Austrian, and Prussian armies into Paris. The Congress of Vienna of 1815 redraws the political map of Europe, giving Russia control over the whole of Poland and establishing Russia as a major force in European affairs. Antiautocratic ideas gain popularity among the young nobility during the military campaigns in the west.

1822–65 Kazakh khanates are gained by Russia.

1825 On Alexander's sudden death, young army officers (the "Decembrists") stage a revolt in favor of the abolition of serfdom and constitutional reform, including a constitutional monarchy. The uprising is suppressed and the new czar, Alexander's brother, Nicholas I, begins a 30-year reign of reactionary policies, characterized by militarism and bureaucracy, which earns him the nickname "the gendarme of Europe."

1830–31 Insurrection in Poland is brutally suppressed.

1848 Revolutions elsewhere in Europe prompt Nicholas to impose new censorship, new restrictions on academic freedom in Russia's relatively young universities, and a prohibition on foreign travel. Russian troops are sent at Austria's request to put down the revolution in Hungary.

1853–56 The Crimean War against Turkey, France, and the UK ends in defeat for Russia. The conflict was prompted by Nicholas's decision to occupy the Balkan provinces of Moldavia and Wallachia in 1853 and Russian threats to British interests in the Mediterranean and to the sovereignty of the Ottoman Empire. Nicholas dies in March 1855 and is succeeded by his son, Alexander II.

1858–60 Russia gains land north of the Amur River and the coastal region of Ussuri, giving it access to the warm-water port of Vladivostok. By 1875 it has gained the whole of the large offshore island of Sakhalin.

1859–78 Russia extends its territory south into the Caucasus, gaining western Georgia and the whole of Armenia.

1860 Russian revolutionary movements emerge, including the influential Narodniks (Populists), who preach that intellectuals could inspire "the people" with revolutionary ideas because the peasantry embody socialism in their communally arranged households. However, in 1874–77 the failure of a Populists' crusade to win the hearts of Russia's peasants leads some factions to turn to terrorism.

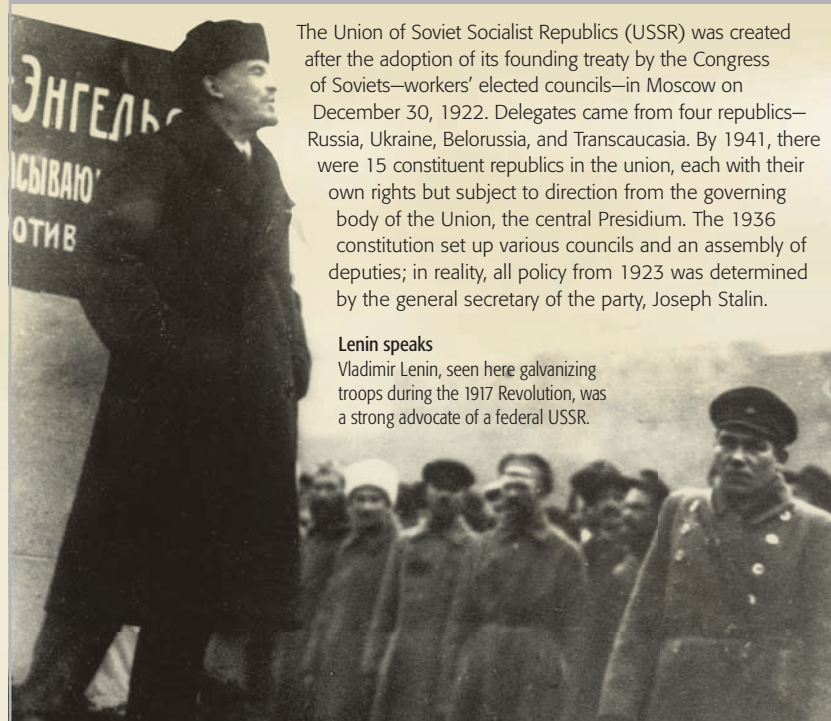
1861 Alexander orders the emancipation of the serfs and begins a period of reform of local government (creating the *zemstvo* system of rural councils), the judiciary, and financial institutions, although the reforms are limited by remaining within an autocratic framework. Massive discontent remains, however, as the serfs have to pay redemption fees for the land they tilled. The discontent is held in check by the secret police and army.

1866–76 Russia expands into the khanates of Bukhara, Khiva, and Kokand.

1867 Russia sells Alaska to the US for \$7.2 million.

DECISIVE MOMENT

THE FIRST SOVIET, 1922



Lenin speaks

Vladimir Lenin, seen here galvanizing troops during the 1917 Revolution, was a strong advocate of a federal USSR.

1881 Russians crush Turkmen resistance at Goktepe.

1881 Alexander II is assassinated in St. Petersburg by the terrorist group Narodnaya Volya (The People's Will), an offshoot of the Populist movement. Alexander III establishes a period of reaction, russification, and militant Orthodoxy. Pogroms against Jewish communities begin.

1884 Russia completes its conquest of Central Asia by acquiring the city of Merv.

1891–1916 Trans-Siberian Railroad is constructed from Moscow to Vladivostok.

1894 The last Russian czar, Nicholas II, accedes to the throne. In the 1890s, Russian industry grows by an average of 8 percent a year, creating a significant and highly localized working class. Marxism begins to attract considerable strength among intellectuals and radicals.

1904–05 Russian war against Japan, caused by rivalry in Manchuria and Korea, ends in defeat for Russia and the loss of southern Sakhalin.

1905 Discontent with war against Japan, high taxation, and industrial distress erupts in revolution. A mutiny on the battleship *Potemkin* in the Black Sea fleet spreads to other units in the army and navy, and there is a general strike, forcing Czar Nicholas to grant a constitution, a legislative Duma, and a prime minister.

1909–14 Rapid economic expansion.

1914 Russia enters World War I against Germany, but suffers huge losses, although it has some successes against Austria-Hungary.

1917 The February Revolution leads to the abdication of Nicholas II. A provisional government is established. In the October Revolution, the Bolsheviks seize power with Lenin as leader.

1918 Treaty of Brest-Litovsk, signed with Germany, ends war. Russia loses Finland, the Baltic States, Poland, Belorussia, Ukraine, and states in the Caucasus.

1918 Nicholas II and family are shot.

1918–21 Civil war breaks out as the Bolshevik Red Army and counter-revolutionaries struggle for control. Bolshevik control is confirmed in 1921.

1920–21 Ukraine, Belorussia, Caucasus states, and Central Asia are reconquered.

1921 "New Economic Policy" relaxes state controls after peasant riots and shortages of food. It allows some private commerce and free trade.

1922 USSR is established.

1924 Lenin dies. The ensuing leadership struggle is eventually won by Stalin.

1928 First Five-Year Plan: forced industrialization and collectivization as the New Economic Policy is abandoned in favor of total state control of industry and agriculture.

1929 Trotsky, founder of the Red Army and political opponent of Stalin, is exiled.

1936–38 Show trials and campaigns by Stalin against actual and suspected members of the opposition send millions to labor camps in Siberia and elsewhere. Up to 7 million are arrested and 3 million killed through execution or internment.



The paper ruble

These czarist bank notes date from the time of the 1917 Revolution. Communist dreams of abolishing money were short-lived even though hyperinflation during the civil war left the paper ruble worthless.